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Punjab in the Late 1970s and My Return to Headquarters

FOLLOWING ITS loss in the sixth Lok Sabha elections in March 1977, the Congress also lost the 1977 elections in Punjab to the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) and Janata Party coalition. The newly elected Punjab government under Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal put some Congress workers and leaders in jail for their activities during the Emergency. Having lost power in the state, former Congress chief minister of Punjab (1972–77) Giani Zail Singh advised Sanjay Gandhi to launch what I have described as Op-1 [1]

The Congress meddling in the affairs of the Akali Dal was nothing new to Punjab. It was done in the early sixties by Congress chief minister Pratap Singh Kairon, who played Master Tara Singh and Sant Fateh Singh against each other to retain his influence over the SGPC. Zail Singh, who after his religious studies at the Sikh Missionary College in Amritsar had started his career as a preacher, used this approach successfully as chief minister by building a 577-km road called Guru Gobind Singh Marg. The road followed the route taken by Guru Gobind Singh, the tenth Sikh guru, during his retreat in AD 1705 from Anandpur Sahib to Talwandi Sabo (Damdama Sahib). Zail Singh inaugurated the road on 10 April 1973 with great fanfare, and led a religious procession on it, stopping on the way at all the major gurudwaras that the road connected.